

generated by all law partnerships for all services in 1994! Of course, this total is only a small amount compared with the nearly \$270 billion that will be paid to the federal government in estate taxes during the same ten-year period (see [Table 7-1](#)).

There is more to being a successful estate attorney than just providing legal advice. The more successful ones also act as mentors and family advisors to the affluent and their heirs. These attorneys have to be especially adept at meeting the needs of the widows and widowers who are their clients. Within the affluent married-couple population, almost all husbands and wives intend to leave their estates to their spouses, since a husband or wife can inherit his or her spouse's estate without paying an estate tax.* This unlimited marital deduction essentially postpones payment of estate taxes until the death of the second spouse.

Affluent widows face a particularly difficult situation. More than half will have been married to the same spouse for more than fifty years. Between 1996 and 2005, there are likely to be four affluent widows created for every one affluent widower. Age is most significant in explaining this variation. Within the millionaire married-couple population, the expected average age of a male decedent (husband) is seventy-five and a half years, while the average age for a female decedent (wife) is eighty-two years. Moreover, males in such cases typically marry women who are on average two years their junior. Thus, in the typical affluent-couple population, the husband who passes away at the age of seventy-five and a half years leaves behind a widow who is two years younger than he was at the time of death. His wife, who became a widow at the age of seventy-three, is expected to live until she is eighty-two. Most women in this scenario never remarry. Therefore, most women are widowed for nine years before their deaths.

It is estimated that during the ten-year period from 1996 to 2005, nearly 296,000 women in the millionaire married-couple population will become widows. Their average inheritance will be approximately \$2 million (in 1990 dollars). During this same period, nearly 72,000 men from this population will become widowers. It is estimated that these men will inherit more than \$125 billion, or an average inheritance of approximately \$1.7 million.

In what states will the demand for estate attorneys be the strongest? We predict that demand in California, Florida, New York, Illinois, Texas, and Pennsylvania will be especially high during the next decade (see [Tables 7-3](#) and [7-4](#)).